

Module 5 — The Sync Mechanics

Module purpose

Dogs learn from what works.

This module helps the owner improve timing, routine, and household consistency so the dog receives clearer information every day.

This is not an obedience class.

This is about reducing mixed signals, rewarding the right moment, building calm routines, and making the home easier for the dog to understand.

What the owner should be able to do after this module

By the end of Module 5, the owner should be able to:

1. Reward the behaviour they want at the right moment.
 2. Notice when they are accidentally rewarding behaviour they do not want.
 3. Use short, clear, consistent household cues.
 4. Build simple calm routines around food, doors, greetings, rest, and attention.
 5. Reduce yelling, repeated commands, and confusing mixed signals.
 6. Create one household agreement so everyone responds the same way.
 7. Know when repeated behaviour problems need trainer or vet support.
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Lesson 1 — Reward the Moment You Want

Scenario

Your dog briefly sits before jumping.

They stop barking for one second before starting again.

They lie down quietly for a few moments, then get up.

They look at you instead of grabbing the lead.

The good moment happens, but it disappears quickly.

By the time you find a treat or say something, the dog is already doing something else.

What the owner needs to notice

Timing matters.

Dogs learn from what happens immediately around their behaviour.

If the owner rewards too late, the dog may not connect the reward to the behaviour the owner wanted.

The useful question is:

What was the dog doing at the exact moment I rewarded them?

Common mistake

Rewarding after the moment has passed.

Examples:

- dog sits, then jumps, then gets attention
- dog stops barking, then barks again, then owner gives food
- dog lies calmly, then gets up and follows, then owner praises
- dog comes inside from toileting, then gets rewarded far away from the toileting spot
- dog paws at the owner, then owner looks, talks, laughs, or touches them

The owner may think they rewarded one thing, but the dog may have learned another.

Better decision rule

Reward the behaviour while it is happening or immediately after it happens.

Ask:

Am I rewarding the behaviour I want, or the behaviour that happened after it?

If the answer is unclear, make the setup easier.

What to do now

Choose one behaviour to reward today.

Do not fix everything.

Pick one:

- four paws on the floor
- quiet pause
- calm sit before food
- looking at the owner
- walking through a door calmly
- lying down quietly
- taking a toy instead of a hand
- returning to the owner
- settling on a mat or bed

Prepare the reward before the situation starts.

Use:

- small food reward
- calm praise
- toy
- access to something the dog wants
- distance from pressure
- permission to move forward

Reward immediately when the behaviour appears.

Keep it simple:

Behaviour happens → reward happens.

Watch for this

Notice whether the dog repeats the behaviour more often.

Also notice whether rewards are happening after:

- jumping
- barking
- grabbing
- pawing
- pushing through doors
- stealing items
- biting clothing
- rushing the food bowl
- demanding attention

If the behaviour increases, it may be working for the dog somehow.

When education is not enough

Seek trainer support if:

- the owner cannot safely manage the situation
- the dog is too over-aroused to take food or respond
- the behaviour involves guarding, snapping, lunging, or biting
- the behaviour is worsening despite clearer timing
- the household cannot agree on one response

Seek vet advice if:

- behaviour changes suddenly
- the dog seems painful, unwell, restless, frantic, or unable to settle
- training suddenly becomes difficult after a health change

Trainer-readiness note

Before asking for help, record:

- behaviour you wanted
 - behaviour that actually got rewarded
 - reward used
 - timing of reward
 - whether the dog repeated the behaviour
 - who was present
 - what happened before the behaviour
 - whether the dog could take food or respond
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Lesson 2 — Stop Accidentally Paying for the Wrong Behaviour

Scenario

Your dog barks for attention.

Someone says:

“Stop it!”

The dog keeps barking.

Your dog jumps on visitors.

People push them down, talk to them, laugh, or pat them while trying to stop them.

The dog jumps again next time.

What the owner needs to notice

Attention can be a reward.

For some dogs, even eye contact, talking, touching, laughing, chasing, or pushing can make a behaviour more likely to happen again.

The dog is not being spiteful.

The behaviour may simply be working.

Common mistake

Reacting strongly to behaviour the owner wants to reduce.

Examples:

- yelling when the dog barks
- chasing when the dog steals a sock
- pushing when the dog jumps
- grabbing when the dog mouths clothing
- repeating the dog's name again and again
- giving food after barking because the owner wants quiet
- opening the door while the dog is pawing or barking

The owner may be trying to stop the behaviour, but the dog may be receiving attention or access.

Better decision rule

Reward the replacement, not the chaos.

Ask:

What should the dog do instead?

Then reward that.

Examples:

- four paws down instead of jumping
- quiet pause instead of barking
- toy in mouth instead of hand biting
- sit before the door opens
- calm waiting before food bowl goes down
- going to a mat instead of crowding visitors

What to do now

Choose one repeating behaviour.

Write:

When my dog does: _____
I will stop rewarding it by: _____
I will reward this instead: _____

Example:

When my dog jumps on visitors,
I will stop rewarding it by asking visitors not to touch, talk, or make eye contact during jumping.
I will reward four paws on the floor with calm attention.

Set the dog up to succeed.

If visitors are too exciting, use:

- lead
- baby gate
- safe room
- food scatter
- mat
- calm greeting plan
- fewer people
- more distance

Do not rely on willpower in a hard situation.

Watch for this

The unwanted behaviour may briefly increase when it stops working.

That does not always mean the plan is wrong. It may mean the dog is trying the old behaviour harder because it used to work.

Keep the replacement easy and rewarding.

When education is not enough

Seek support if:

- the behaviour is intense or unsafe
- the dog becomes frustrated or aggressive
- the owner cannot prevent rehearsal
- children, visitors, or other animals are at risk
- the behaviour is linked to fear, panic, guarding, or distress
- the household cannot apply the same response

Trainer-readiness note

Tell a trainer:

- what the dog gets from the behaviour
- attention, food, play, distance, access, escape, or movement
- what replacement behaviour you tried
- whether the behaviour increased, decreased, or changed
- how the household responded

- whether safety concerns are present
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Lesson 3 — Calm Routines Before Big Feelings

Scenario

Every day has the same problem points.

The dog rushes the food bowl.
They push through doors.
They jump at greetings.
They bark when ignored.
They grab the lead before walks.
They become frantic before play.

The owner feels like the dog has no manners.

What the owner needs to notice

Many “manners” problems are routine problems.

The dog is learning:

- what happens before food
- what opens doors
- what starts play
- what gets attention
- what makes the lead appear
- what makes people move
- what ends waiting

If every exciting event begins with chaos, the dog may rehearse chaos every day.

Common mistake

Waiting until the dog is already overexcited.

Another mistake is asking for too much too late.

For example:

- expecting calm after the food bowl appears
- asking for perfect behaviour when guests are already inside
- clipping the lead on while the dog is jumping
- opening the door during barking
- playing harder when the dog is already frantic

Better decision rule

Build the routine before the dog tips over.

Ask:

What is the calmest version of this moment my dog can manage?

Start there.

What to do now

Pick one daily routine.

Use the same pattern each time.

Food routine

1. Prepare food calmly.
2. Wait for one tiny calm moment.
3. Put the bowl down.
4. If the dog jumps or rushes, pause.
5. Try again at an easier level.

Door routine

1. Approach door.
2. Wait for a quiet pause.
3. Open slightly.
4. If dog surges, close calmly.
5. Reward calm waiting by opening again.

Greeting routine

1. Keep greetings low-key.
2. Reward four paws on the floor.
3. Ask visitors to ignore jumping.
4. Use a gate, lead, or distance if needed.

Attention routine

1. Notice quiet behaviour.
2. Give calm attention before barking starts.
3. Withdraw attention from demand barking if safe and appropriate.
4. Reward the quiet pause.

Watch for this

Track whether the dog becomes calmer when the routine becomes predictable.

Signs of improvement:

- shorter excitement bursts
- quicker recovery
- more waiting
- less jumping
- less barking
- more checking in
- easier redirection
- more settling after the event

When education is not enough

Seek support if:

- the dog cannot calm even with easier routines
- arousal escalates into biting, snapping, guarding, or lunging
- the dog becomes distressed when access is delayed
- the household cannot manage doors, food, greetings, or visitors safely
- the dog appears frantic, unwell, or unable to rest

Trainer-readiness note

Record:

- routine chosen
 - what happens before excitement starts
 - what the dog does
 - what the owner does
 - what reward is used
 - what makes it easier
 - what makes it worse
 - whether the dog recovers afterward
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Lesson 4 — One Household, One Rule

Scenario

One person lets the dog jump up.

Another person gets angry about jumping.

One person feeds from the table.

Another person wants the dog to stop begging.

One person repeats commands.

Another person uses different words.

The dog seems confused, and the household blames the dog.

What the owner needs to notice

Dogs learn from patterns.

If each person responds differently, the dog receives mixed information.

The problem may not be the dog's attitude.

The problem may be the household system.

Common mistake

Expecting the dog to understand rules humans have not agreed on.

Examples:

- "Off," "down," "no," and "stop" all used for different things
- some people reward jumping while others punish it
- visitors ignore the plan
- children use food or toys inconsistently
- one person allows couch access and another removes the dog
- the dog gets attention only when they interrupt

Better decision rule

Make the human rule first.

Ask:

What will every person do when this happens?

If humans cannot answer, the dog cannot learn the rule reliably.

What to do now

Create a family cue agreement.

Choose:

- one word for the behaviour
- one response for unwanted behaviour
- one reward for desired behaviour
- one management plan when the dog cannot cope

Keep cues short.

Examples:

Situation	Household rule
Jumping	Everyone ignores jumping and rewards four paws down
Door rushing	Door opens only during a calm pause
Food bowl	Bowl lowers when dog is calm enough
Biting clothes	Pause movement and offer toy
Stolen item	Swap, do not chase
Barking for attention	Reward quiet pause, not demand barking
Rest area	No one disturbs the dog while resting

Watch for this

The dog may improve when the household becomes predictable.

Watch for:

- fewer repeated commands
- less frustration
- easier recovery
- more offered calm behaviours
- more consistency between people
- fewer arguments about what to do

When education is not enough

Seek support if:

- household members cannot safely follow the same plan
- children are involved and safety is uncertain
- the dog guards food, toys, people, or resting places
- the dog snaps, bites, or lunges
- behaviour is fear-based, aggressive, or worsening
- the owner needs a trainer to coach the household, not just the dog

Trainer-readiness note

Bring the family cue agreement to the trainer.

Tell them:

- which rules are inconsistent
- who is struggling to follow the plan
- what behaviours are rewarded by accident
- which situations create conflict

- whether visitors or children are involved
 - whether safety concerns exist
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Tool 1 — Reward Timing Practice Card

Use this for one behaviour at a time.

Choose one behaviour

- ☐ Four paws on floor
- ☐ Quiet pause
- ☐ Calm sit
- ☐ Looking at owner
- ☐ Settling on bed/mat
- ☐ Taking toy instead of hand
- ☐ Waiting at door
- ☐ Calm before food
- ☐ Other: ____

Prepare before the moment

- ☐ Reward is ready
- ☐ Situation is easy enough
- ☐ Owner knows what behaviour to reward
- ☐ Household knows not to interrupt

During the moment

- ☐ Reward while behaviour is happening
- ☐ Use calm voice
- ☐ Keep session short
- ☐ Stop before dog becomes frustrated

Afterward

- ☐ Did the dog repeat the behaviour?
 - ☐ Was the timing clear?
 - ☐ Did anything else get rewarded by accident?
 - ☐ What will be easier next time?
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Tool 2 — Calm Routine Card

Use this for food, doors, greetings, lead, play, or attention.

Routine chosen

The routine I want to improve is:

Dog currently does

Before the routine, my dog usually:

Calm version

The smallest calm behaviour I can reward is:

Examples:

- one second quiet
- four paws down
- looking at owner
- standing still
- sitting briefly
- stepping back
- waiting without barking
- settling on mat

Owner plan

- ☐ Make the situation easier
- ☐ Reward tiny calm moment
- ☐ Do not wait for perfection
- ☐ Pause if dog becomes frantic
- ☐ Repeat the same pattern next time

Review after three days

- ☐ Dog recovers faster
- ☐ Dog repeats calm behaviour more often
- ☐ Dog is still too overexcited
- ☐ Routine needs to be easier
- ☐ Trainer support may be needed

Tool 3 — Family Cue Agreement

Use this before blaming the dog for mixed signals.

Situation	Cue or signal	What everyone does	What everyone avoids	Reward
Jumping				
Barking for attention				
Door rushing				
Food bowl excitement				
Biting clothes/hands				
Stolen items				
Rest area				
Visitors				

Household rule

We will use one plan for one week before changing it.

Review

After one week, ask:

- Did everyone follow the same rule?
- Which situation improved?
- Which situation is still unclear?
- Did anyone reward the unwanted behaviour by accident?
- Is the behaviour safe enough to continue self-guided practice?
- Do we need trainer support?

Tool 4 — Accidental Reward Audit

Use this when an unwanted behaviour keeps repeating.

Behaviour	What happens right after?	What might the dog be getting?	Replacement behaviour	New owner response
Jumping		attention/touch/movement	four paws down	
Barking		attention/access	quiet pause	
Stealing items		chase/game	toy swap	
Pawing		touch/food/attention	sit/settle	

Behaviour	What happens right after?	What might the dog be getting?	Replacement behaviour	New owner response
Door rushing		access outside	calm pause	
Lead grabbing		walk starts/play	calm hold still	

Module completion action

The owner can complete Module 5 when they can confirm:

- ☐ They can choose one behaviour to reward
- ☐ They understand reward timing
- ☐ They have identified one accidental reward pattern
- ☐ They have built one calm routine
- ☐ The household has agreed on one cue or response
- ☐ They are avoiding yelling, physical correction, dominance framing, and punishment-based responses
- ☐ They know when repeated or unsafe behaviour needs trainer or vet support

Module 5 dashboard summary

Current focus

Make daily signals clearer.

Today's action

Pick one routine and reward the smallest calm moment.

Capability gained

Reward timing and household consistency.

Decision rule

Reward what you want repeated.

Escalation reminder

Repeated unsafe behaviour, guarding, biting, severe anxiety, sudden behaviour change, pain signs, or household safety concerns need professional support.

Trainer-readiness output

If problems continue, the owner should be able to describe:

- what behaviour they want
 - what behaviour is happening instead
 - what reward may be maintaining it
 - what replacement behaviour they tried
 - how quickly they rewarded
 - who responded differently
 - what routine or cue is inconsistent
 - whether safety concerns are present
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Internal source map

This section is for repo/source control only. It should not appear inside the learner flow.

Core source base

Module 5 is supported primarily by:

- RSPCA Knowledgebase on reward-based dog training: RSPCA supports training that sets the dog up to succeed, rewards wanted behaviour, and avoids aversive techniques, physical punishment, and dominance assertion. It also gives a jumping example where attention is given only when four paws are on the ground, with the reward delivered as soon as the desired behaviour happens.
- RSPCA Knowledgebase on why training matters: training supports mental stimulation, cognitive wellbeing, appropriate behaviour, safety, trust, and clear communication. RSPCA also states that dogs repeat behaviours that work for them, rewards vary in value, yelling can inadvertently reinforce behaviour, and physical punishment must not be used.
- RSPCA Knowledgebase on dominance training: RSPCA states dominance assumptions are flawed and often harmful, and recommends focusing on desired behaviours, rewarding responses that lead to those behaviours, removing rewards for unwanted behaviour, and avoiding force, pain, distress, and aversive equipment or methods.
- RSPCA NSW puppy guidance: puppies benefit from predictable routines, safe spaces, rest, positive encouragement, choice and control, and not being yelled at or punished; the page also notes that chewing, licking, and sniffing can be relaxing for dogs.
- AVSAB Humane Dog Training position statement: evidence supports reward-based methods for canine training; training is most effective when it teaches the animal what to do instead of punishing unwanted behaviour; management and reinforcement are recommended for common issues such as jumping, barking, and housetraining; aversive methods relying on force, pain, or emotional/physical discomfort should not be used.
- Earlier Gemini rough scan: retained only as an idea pool and not used as primary curriculum evidence because it included weak or non-preferred sources.

Claims requiring careful wording

Reward timing

Approved wording:

Reward the behaviour while it is happening or immediately after it happens.

Avoid:

Timing alone fixes all behaviour.

Accidental reinforcement

Approved wording:

If a behaviour keeps repeating, check what the dog may be getting from it.

Avoid:

The dog is manipulating the owner.

Calm routines

Approved wording:

Build predictable routines and reward small calm moments before the dog becomes overexcited.

Avoid:

Demand calm after the dog is already over threshold.

Household consistency

Approved wording:

The household should agree on one response so the dog receives clearer information.

Avoid:

The dog is pushing boundaries or being obnoxious.

Aversive/dominance methods

Approved wording:

Avoid yelling, physical correction, intimidation, dominance framing, or punishment-based responses.

Avoid:

Use correction to show the dog who is in charge.

Escalation

Approved wording:

Seek trainer or vet support when behaviour is unsafe, escalating, fear-based, linked to guarding, linked to pain or illness, or not improving with clearer routines.

Avoid:

This module replaces trainer or vet support.

Codex implementation note

Store this as:

```
``text id="l0p7fb" /docs/education/curriculum/05-the-sync-mechanics.md
```

Optional supporting files:

```
```text id="6xa8oh"  
/docs/education/tools/reward-timing-practice-card.md
/docs/education/tools/calm-routine-card.md
/docs/education/tools/family-cue-agreement.md
/docs/education/tools/accidental-reward-audit.md
/docs/education/research/module-5-the-sync-mechanics-source-map.md
```